

The Clockless God

Culo

1



A narrow shop lined floor to ceiling with clocks, in grey street light. The brass bell over the door swings as the door opens and makes no sound at all.

Someone has wedged its clapper with a twist of paper.

Dec: Monsieur Roux? C'est moi. L'Irlandais. For the gears.

Nothing answers him. Not one tick.

Two hundred clocks cover the walls, and all of them are silent. A row of cat clocks has its eyes fixed, every one looking left.

Dec: That's very quiet for a clock shop.

Roux: It's Sunday.

Dec: It's Monday. I said Monday, didn't I? For the escapement wheels.

Roux: Who are you?

Dec: Dec. Declan Hartley. I was here Thursday. You called me a thief because I offered you forty euro for a mainspring.

Roux: You are a thief.

Roux says it with relief, as if he has found one thing in the room where he left it.

Roux: I closed the shop on Saturday night. I went to bed. Now it is Sunday, and I come down to wind them, and they are all...

He lifts one hand and lets it fall.

Roux: They are all at nine.

Dec looks properly. The regulators, the carriage clocks, the ship's clock, the cat clocks, the cheap plastic one over the workshop door. Every face says nine exactly.

Dec: Right. Okay. That's a lot of nine.

Roux: Is it Sunday?

This time it is a question from a very old man, and his voice cracks on it.

Dec comes round the counter. Roux smells of machine oil and pipe tobacco, and of something sweet and dusty.

Dec: It's Monday the twenty-third of March. Have you eaten anything? Had a drink of water?

Roux: I had my coffee. Everything tastes of cloves. Cloves and slate. Like licking a church roof.

He sticks his tongue out like a child at bad medicine. It is the wrong colour: a dull smeared grey, as if he has been sucking a pencil.

Dec: Grey tongue. Cloves. Slate.

Dec files it away, the way his father taught him to keep the screws from a lock: in the order they came out.

Roux: Somebody has been in here. They have been touching my clocks.

Dec: Did anyone come to the door last night?

Roux: Nobody comes to the door. I lock the front, I lock the back, I go upstairs, I sleep, I come down. And now it is Sunday.

Dec: Monday.

Roux: Don't correct me, thief.

Dec: That's more like it.

A tall plain oak clock stands by the counter, the kind a farmer hangs his hat on. Behind its little glass window, the pendulum hangs dead.

The pendulum hangs at a slant. Dec shines his torch up into the case.

Dec: Well, hello.

A sliver of brass, no bigger than a matchstick, has been pushed between the crutch and the pendulum rod.

Dec: Somebody wound you, set you to nine, and then jammed you so you couldn't go. On purpose.

Lower down, on the bare oak inside the trunk, there is chalk.

It is small and careful. Whoever drew it had all the time in the world.

Dec: Monsieur Roux? Did you draw something in your clock?

Roux: I don't draw. I mend.

Dec: Grand. Just checking.

He takes a photograph without touching the chalk, and closes the little door the way you close a door on a sleeping baby. Or a bomb.

Trays of springs and wheels lie like jewels under a strip light. At the far end is the back door to the courtyard.

The door is locked. Dec looks at it with a professional's interest, and then with a different kind.

Dec: Ah, now. That's not right at all.

Roux: What? What's not right?

Dec: When did you put a new lock on your back door?

Roux: I didn't! That door has the old lock. My father's lock.

Dec: Well, it hasn't now. It has a thing out of a blister pack.

Dec: See those lines round the keyway? That's a pick.

Somebody picked this badly, dragging a rake in and out like he was raking leaves.

Dec: A professional leaves you nothing. You'd never know I'd been there.

He is explaining a lock to a man who has just lost a day of his life, and he can't stop. It is what his mouth does when he is frightened.

Dec: But here's the thing. There's a thumb-turn on this side, and it's locked from the inside.

Dec: So whoever picked it from the yard never went out this way. It's a stage set.

Roux: Then how did they come in?

Dec: The front. With a key. Or you let them in.

Dec unrolls his canvas roll on his knee: twelve picks and two tension wrenches, each in its own pocket. He calls them the cutlery.

Dec: If I pick it from this side, the pins will tell me...

He has the wrench in the keyway and the hook going in after it, tongue between his teeth.

Out front, the bell over the door rings, loud and clear. Somebody has unjammed it.

Pichon: Do not move, monsieur. And please do not finish whatever it is you are doing to that door.

Two young officers fill the doorway. Between them stands a

round, tired man.

Pichon: Commissaire Pichon. Police judiciaire. And you are?

Dec: Dec. Declan Hartley. Look, this isn't what it looks like.

Pichon looks at it: the man on his knees, the hook in the keyhole, eleven more picks laid out like surgical instruments.

Roux: That is the thief! He wanted my mainspring for forty euros!

Pichon: Monsieur Hartley.

He says the name the way a doctor says the name of a rash.

Pichon: At eleven minutes past nine a neighbour reports a break-in. At nine thirty-one I find you inside, at the back door, with burglary tools.

Pichon: I was at breakfast. I would like to go back to breakfast. Please make it easy for me.

Dec: I'm a locksmith. I build escape rooms. You lock people in a room, they find the clues, they pay you.

Dec: I'm building one for the Fondation Vaulmont. A medieval clockmaker's cell. I was buying gears! Monsieur Roux, tell him!

Roux considers this.

Roux: He is a thief. But I don't think he stopped my clocks. He can't even get the price of a mainspring right.

Dec: Thank you.

Pichon: Stand up, please. Slowly. Leave the little knives on the

floor.

Dec: They're picks, not knives. They wouldn't cut butter.

Dec stands and leaves the cutlery on the floor. An officer takes his arm, not roughly, and turns him to face the wall.

Dec: Can I say one thing? The back door's locked from the inside. Somebody picked it from the yard to fake a break-in, but they never left that way.

Dec: And the clocks were stopped on purpose. There's brass jammed in the pendulum, and a drawing in chalk inside his clock. A clock with nine at the top.

Dec: And his tongue's gone grey. He says everything tastes of cloves.

There is a pause behind him.

Pichon: His tongue.

Another pause, longer. When Pichon speaks again, his voice has sat up.

Pichon: A clock. With nine at the top.

Dec: In the longcase. Inside the door.

Footsteps cross the shop. The little door of the longcase opens. There is only the silence of two hundred stopped clocks and a delivery van beeping somewhere in the street.

The little door closes again, very softly.

Pichon: Monsieur Hartley. You are under arrest.

Dec: For what? I've just told you...

Pichon: Exactly. You have told me a great deal more than you should know.

He tucks the folded napkin into his raincoat pocket and nods to the door, where the street and the police car wait.

Pichon: Come. We will talk about it over lunch.

Dec looks back once at the longcase clock, at Roux on his stool, at the cutlery on the floor.

He has never in his life managed to keep his mouth shut, and this doesn't feel like the morning to start.

Go with the commissaire, and keep talking - turn to section 15.

2



A stone stairwell, grey light from the street door. Dec sits on the bottom step with two paper cups of coffee and a folded newspaper, like a large untidy dog told to wait.

Dec: I brought coffee. One black, one with everything in it. You take whichever.

He holds out the black one. She never said which. He guessed wrong. She takes it, mostly to stop him holding it out.

Inès: How did you find me?

Dec: You told Pichon. I've a very good memory for addresses. It is what we do in my line of work. You remember where the doors are.

Dec: And there is a bad thing.

He hands her the newspaper, folded to page four.

Inès reads it twice. The coffee goes cold in her other hand.

Inès: Lassalle. He telephoned Morel on Saturday to ask if we could be faster.

Dec: The man who sent me the gear and the man who sent you the painting. In the river. Of a heart attack. The day the clocks stopped.

Four floors up, a door bangs. Morel starts down the stairs and stops on the first landing.

Inès: I am going to the quai d'Orléans.

Dec: Grand. I will come with you.

Inès: I did not ask you.

Dec: No, I know. But I have a good feeling about this door.

The small door set in the green carriage door stands an inch open. Upstairs, the office door stands open all the way.

Inside, panelled walls and tall windows over the river. Every book lies open on the carpet, spine up, in rows. Every filing drawer is pulled out to exactly the same length. Every picture stands against the wall with its brown paper backing slit down the middle.

Inès: This is not a burglary. Burglars are stupid. This is someone going through a room square by square.

Dec: And they did not find it. They have gone round in a ring. Bookcase, cabinet, pictures. Every drawer of the desk is out.

Dec: But they have not done the desk itself. Either they were interrupted, or they do not know what this is.

He steps between the open books to a heavy mahogany bureau with a high back of pigeonholes, all emptied onto the floor.

Dec: Second Empire. A workshop in the Faubourg Saint-Antoine made hundreds of these for notaries, and every one has a secret drawer.

Dec: Because they only knew the one trick. Take out the middle pigeonhole, reach in to the elbow, and at the back on the left there is a peg…

A click. A panel Inès would have sworn was solid drops forward on a hidden hinge. Behind it, a drawer no deeper than a book.

Dec: Every desk of that make. Every single one.

In the drawer there are three things.

Dec: The gate of hell. The ninth niche.

Inès: The Barrière d'Enfer was an old toll gate in the city wall. At Denfert-Rochereau. Where the catacombs are.

Dec: Oh, that is cheerful.

Inès takes the watch. It is warm. Her thumb finds the catch on the back of the case.

The floor of the landing creaks. One plank, under one big careful weight.

His small pale eyes go to the open drawer, then to the watch in Inès's hand. Without a word, he comes into the room.

Dec: Right. Okay. Window.

Grey zinc slopes wet with drizzle, chimney pots, a satellite dish, a pot of dead geraniums. The Seine far below on one side, a courtyard of bins on the other.

Dec: Do not look down.

Inès: Basszus.

She has looked down.

Behind them the zinc booms under a great weight. The bald man is not running. He walks, as if he has all day.

At the end of the ridge, the roof stops. A light well drops between two buildings, a metre and a bit wide. On the far side, a lower roof with a skylight propped open on a stick.

Dec jumps it, skids, catches the skylight frame, and turns round with both hands out.

Dec: Come on.

Inès: No. I cannot. I am afraid of heights. I clean skies. I do not jump over holes.

Dec: You can. It is a metre. You have walked further for a

coffee.

The zinc booms behind her. She looks round.

He is not looking at her. A grey pigeon is caught by one foot in the bird netting along the gutter, beating itself against the zinc.

The huge man reaches out slowly, the way you reach for a sleeping child. He folds its wings. With one thick finger he works the net off its foot, holds it a moment against his coat, and opens his hands.

The pigeon goes up past Inès's face in a clatter of wings.

And Inès, without deciding to, jumps.

Dec catches her by both wrists. They go over sideways against the skylight, the stick falls out, and the skylight bangs shut on Dec's elbow.

Dec: Ah, Jaysus, Mary and the holy saints and all their cousins...

Across the gap, the bald man studies the drop, then takes out a phone and walks slowly back the way he came.

A stone and iron bridge over a green-grey Seine, the tip of the island behind them, rain on the parapet.

Dec: You jumped.

Inès: I could not. And then I did. Do not make a thing of it.

Dec: It was only a metre.

Inès: It was a metre and twenty.

Dec: I will grant you the twenty.

Her other hand is still clenched round the silver watch. The chain has printed links into her palm. She presses the catch. The back springs open.

Inès: Dec. What is this?

It is the first time she has used his name. He bends over her hand and, for once, goes quiet.

Dec: That is a lock.

The shop is ticking again like light rain. Two hundred clocks back at their business, the cat clocks eyes going left and right. Someone has wiped the chalk out of the longcase.

Roux: A day! A whole day! At eighty-one I have counted how many I have left. And the police send me a boy with a pimple to ask if I have been drinking!

Dec: Had you?

Roux: You are the thief who brought me my water. Sit. Mind the cuckoo, he bites.

Roux will not touch the watch on the counter. He looks at it the way a man looks at a dog that once bit him.

Dec: Anselme. Before Sunday. Did anyone ask you for something you would not do?

Roux: Everybody. That is what a clockmaker is. A man who says no.

Roux: Two jobs this winter. The gentleman came once. After

that, only a young man in a grey coat with a parcel.

Inès: What gentleman?

Roux: Grey suit, very good. Silver hair brushed back. A voice like warm oil. He had one of those on a chain. A very good watch to have no hands.

Dec and Inès keep their eyes on Roux. It takes some effort.

Roux: The first job was a lock. A copy of a fourteenth-century letter lock. Nine wheels. Turn each to a letter, and if they spell the word, the bar drops.

Dec: What was the word?

Roux: I do not know! The drawings give the gates by number, not letter. The young man brought the last wheel's position in a sealed envelope and stood over me while I cut it.

Roux: He said it was a matter of faith. Faith! In my shop!

Inès: And the second job?

Roux: The one I did not do. Station clocks, hospital clocks, the receivers in the traffic lights. They all listen to Allouis, the long-wave transmitter. It sends out the real time and every radio clock in France obeys.

Roux: They wanted the receivers changed to listen to a different voice. For an exhibition. I said a clock listens to Allouis as a priest listens to God, and I put him out of my shop. Ten days ago.

The cuckoo over the workshop door shoots out and says

cuckoo four times. Dec jumps.

Dec: Then on Sunday someone takes a day off you. Because you said no.

Roux's silence is answer enough.

Roux spreads five sheets of old drawings from a cardboard tube, weighed down with a carriage clock, a jar of screws, his loupe, and after a moment's thought, the handless watch.

Inès: Brother Anselm Vey made me. Thirteen forty-nine.

Roux: The plague year. Everybody was dying and this one made locks. The word was never on the drawings. The young man said so. Vey kept it in his book.

Dec: It is the same lock. On the watch. It is a picture of this lock.

Roux: Of course. It is their sign. Every one of them carries the lock, and none of them carries the word. You see, thief? You are not so stupid.

Roux: Take the tube. Every time I open it I taste cloves.

Inès: Anselme. Show me your tongue.

With enormous dignity, he does. Still grey, fainter, like the shadow of a thumbprint on glass.

Inès: I restored an apothecary's sign once. Sixteen hundreds. One panel was a man in bed, tongue grey, spiced wine, cloves round the jug, a plant with white trumpet flowers.

Inès: The rhyme said: give this to a man and he will owe you a

day.

Roux: White trumpets. Datura. My grandmother grew it for the rats.

The anger goes out of his face. What is left is an old man in a work coat.

Roux: Somebody gave me that? And drew in my longcase? My father's clock.

Dec's hand is on the old man's shoulder. It feels like a bird's.

Dec: We will find out who. I promise you.

Roux: Thief. You promise like a thief.

Dec: The warm-oil man wants the clocks of Paris to hear a different voice. Roux says no and loses a day. Lassalle is in the river. And they want my room finished for an eclipse at the Panthéon.

Dec: I do not know what any of that means.

Inès: Neither do I. But I know where this is.

Dec: Under the ground. With the bones.

Inès: Six million of them, more or less. The ninth niche will not be in the part with the gift shop.

She scrolls to a number and looks at it as if a wasp has landed on her hand.

Inès: My mother's hairdresser has a cousin who goes down there at night. Illegally. A philosophy student. They call her La Taupe.

Dec: The Mole. Is she good?

Inès: I have never met her. My mother's hairdresser says she is very good, and also completely insane.

Her thumb hovers over the call button.

Call La Taupe and go down to the ninth niche - turn to section 6.

3



Morel has a rule about Sundays. But the skylight is lit, and the Allegory of the Sundial stands on the easel under Inès's UV lamp.

He is working on the gap in the Latin line. Too deep, too fast, too much solvent, right where the painter's ghost ticks lie in the ground.

Inès: Jean-Paul. Stop. You're taking off the ground.

The scalpel goes skittering across the floor. His face is grey and wet.

Morel: Inès. You said a week. Your family.

Inès: I lied. So did you.

She has had a list ready since Basel, beginning with the flyleaf. She doesn't need it. He puts his face in his hands and cries, the way a tap drips.

She switches off the UV lamp, pulls up the other stool and waits.

Morel: The gallery, in two thousand and nineteen. My partner went to Brazil, then came the virus. Three banks. My wife still thinks the flat in Vincennes is ours.

Morel: Then Lassalle came. My notary for years. He had a client, a patron of the arts, who would buy my debts. For a few small favours.

Inès: Vaulmont.

Morel flinches as if she has hit him.

Morel: A valuation. A painting lent for a party. Then last autumn they asked if I still remembered my radio.

Morel: As a boy I built long-wave transmitters in my father's shed in Brittany. I told Lassalle once, at dinner, as a joke.

Morel: They gave me figures to check. Power, frequency, range. A son et lumière, they said. I wrote my name in the front of the notebook like a schoolboy.

Morel: I didn't ask what it was for. That's what I was paid for. Not to ask.

Inès: And the painting?

Morel: They need a word under the varnish for their ceremony on the first. I'm a businessman with a diploma, Inès. I can't see what you see. So I gave it to you.

Morel: You'd find the word, I'd take it to them, and you'd never know. Nobody would be hurt.

Inès: Gérard Lassalle is in the river. Anselme Roux lost a day.

Morel: I know! On Friday a young man telephoned. Very polite. He said Lassalle was afraid at the end, and fear is a debt like any other.

Morel: He hoped I wasn't afraid. They expect the word by Sunday night.

Inès: Did you find it?

Morel: No. I never could.

She believes him. She tells him nothing about the tower, or REMIT, or the R and the E in her notebook.

Four floors down, the street bell rings. A long, polite, unhurried ring. Morel goes the colour of old paper.

Even footsteps climb all four flights, and the man who reaches the top has lost no breath. He looks round the room like someone who has paid for it.

Vaulmont: Madame Varga. Forgive me for coming on a Sunday. Auguste de Vaulmont.

The voice is warm oil, poured slowly. She last heard it under

the Barrière d'Enfer, saying Lassalle has been remitted.

Inès: Monsieur de Vaulmont.

Her own voice comes out quite normal. She will be proud of that later.

Vaulmont: I've come for the Allegory. It's needed for the vigil on Wednesday. My people are downstairs with a van.

He stands before the painting, hands behind his back, and looks at the square of blue sky she uncovered.

Vaulmont: You have very good hands. I've owned this picture thirty years and never knew the sky was that colour.

Inès: You're the anonymous buyer.

Vaulmont: The owner. Poor Gérard loved his little fictions. I asked him for the best hands in Paris, and he found them.

Vaulmont: You were in the mountains, I think. The air on the plateau is very clear in March. One can hear bells for miles.

In her apron pockets, her hands close into fists.

Vaulmont: I knew your father a little. Zoltán Varga. He drove the twenty-eight in Lyon, past the Hôtel-Dieu, and sang in Hungarian at red lights. A fine baritone.

Vaulmont: To lose one's days like that, one by one. The cruellest debt is the one we pay without knowing we owe it.

Inès stands quite still. He hasn't said a word a stranger could call a threat. He has simply told her what he holds.

Vaulmont: Your Monsieur Hartley is building us a charming

room. I do hope nothing interrupts his contract.

Vaulmont: And Jean-Paul's affairs are so complicated. This atelier is mortgaged to a bank on whose board I sit.

Vaulmont: We all hold a little of each other's time, Madame Varga. We're all in debt to someone.

He opens his silver watch, the way any man checks the time, and looks into it.

Vaulmont: Did you find the word?

Inès: No.

Vaulmont: No. I don't suppose you did.

Two men in grey overalls carry the painting down in blankets. A van waits with its back doors open.

Vaulmont: Brother Kessler will take it from here. He's very good with fragile things.

Kessler lifts the painting into the van as gently as if it were asleep. Vaulmont gets into a long dark car and is gone.

Inès has forty-one photographs, in the cloud and on a memory stick in her coat. She has nine ticks, an R, an E, and REMIT. She doesn't have the painting.

Morel: What do I do, Inès?

Inès: Go home. Lock your door. Don't drink anything anyone gives you.

She rang him at ten, at half past and at eleven. Then she rang Dec, who came on a hired bicycle in nineteen minutes. The

door wasn't locked.

On the low table sit a cup and saucer, with a finger's depth of cold tea.

Inès: Jean-Paul. Can you hear me?

His mouth moves.

Morel: Sunday.

His tongue is grey, much darker than Roux's.

Dec is already on the phone to the emergency services, spelling the address twice in his terrible French.

Inès: They aren't angry with him. It's housekeeping. A debt that stopped being useful, written off.

Dec: And now they've one restorer left.

Inès: Me.

Dec rings off. The next number in his phone says Commissaire Pichon.

Dec: Pichon would want to know about this.

Inès: Pichon answers to the prefect. And the prefect is on Fabien's list, Dec. He's drinking the wine on Wednesday.

Dec: Pichon also fed me a cassoulet and let me go.

In the armchair, Morel stares at the wall. On the mantelpiece the carriage clock says nine and stays there.

Take everything to Pichon, prefect or no prefect - turn to

section 11.

Trust no one in uniform: stop the vigil yourselves - turn to section 10.

4



Three people pressed into a hollow of cold stone, the stone door pulled almost shut. Inès feels Dec's heart hammering through his jacket.

The door swings open. Candlelight spills in.

Inès counts. Eighteen. Eight pairs stop on the stone steps in front of eight niches. The ninth pair goes on to the altar.

The niche with three idiots in waders pressed into the back of it, they leave empty.

The chanting stops. Somebody at the altar turns the pages of the ledger.

VOICE: Lassalle has been remitted.

A man's voice, quiet, cultivated. Someone who has never had to shout, because people lean closer to hear him.

Inès: Warm oil. Roux said a voice like warm oil.

VOICE: He was afraid. Fear is a debt like any other. He has paid it. Pray for him.

VOICE: Brothers. Our restorer is close to the word. Our clocks are ready.

VOICE: In seven days the moon will cover the sun. At the hour of None the voice from Allouis will speak for us, and the city will hear its debt called in.

VOICE: And the Seventh will collect. Mutuo datum.

HOODS: Reddetur.

Inès: Given as a loan. It shall be repaid.

Inès: Our restorer. Our restorer is close to the word.

In the dark, Dec's hand finds hers. She grips it hard enough to hurt them both.

The candles go out pair by pair, the chant fading down the galleries. The last pair stops in the doorway to pull the stone door shut. One of them is far larger than the other.

The door closes. On the other side, a heavy iron sound, like a bolt going home.

La Taupe: We're locked in a cult's bedroom under the fourteenth and nobody knows we're here.

Dec: Ah, now. Locked's my department.

He puts his whole long body against the stone door. It won't move a whisper. His lamp swings round the walls, and stops.

Dec unrolls the cutlery on the chapel floor like he is laying a table for Sunday dinner. His hands are shaking. By the second pick, they are not.

Dec: Old lever lock. Two levers. Not been opened since Napoleon was a boy. She's going to be a right...

The lock makes a noise like a kicked gate.

Dec: ...there she is. Good girl.

La Taupe: Drainage. Eighteenth century. Mon Dieu, it's beautiful. Follow me exactly. Exactly.

Wet to the neck, all three of them start to laugh, so hard that a light comes on in a window above.

Inès laughs until it turns into something else, and then back. She wipes her glasses on the inside of her collar.

Inès: I'm going to the Jura.

Dec: Right. I'm going with you.

Inès: Why?

Dec: Professional reasons. It's Vey's lock. If his clock's in the Jura, his lock's in the Jura, and I want to see it.

Inès: Purely professionally.

Dec: Totally.

Grey suburbs give way to green fields.

Dec: My father was a locksmith in Galway forty years. Hartley and Son on the van in red, before there was a son to speak of.

Dec: He used to say every lock's a story about what somebody's afraid of. Three deadbolts on an empty flat, he's not afraid of burglars. He's afraid of someone in particular.

Dec: He died in twenty-one. Turns out I'm a very good locksmith and a very bad businessman. Somebody's painted the van white and does plumbing in it.

Dec: So. Escape rooms. You build a story about being afraid, and people pay to get out.

He looks up. She is watching him over her glasses.

Dec: Sorry. I talk. It's a thing.

Inès: I know. Go on.

A thin young man in a long grey coat steps off their train three carriages down, glances at the board, and looks away very quickly at nothing.

Dec: Inès. Don't look round.

She looks round. Of course she does.

Dec: The chain on his waistcoat. I'll bet you the rest of this pretzel there's a watch on it with no hands.

Inès: I don't want the rest of your pretzel. Platform four. Walk normally.

Dec: I always walk normally.

Inès: You walk like a stepladder somebody's trying to carry.

The young man in grey sits at the far end of the carriage behind a Swiss newspaper.

Dec: He's been on the same page since Basel. Pharmaceutical share prices. That's not a share-prices face.

Inès: Then stop looking at him. You are less discreet than the mountains.

Her phone buzzes. She reads it, goes still, and turns the screen to him.

Dec: He gave you his number?

Inès: I took it off his card while he was eating.

She types with one finger: I am with my mother. Sends it. Puts the phone face down.

Dec: Nine minutes of nine o'clock, in a station at rush hour. And the warm-oil fella said our restorer. Like you're theirs.

Inès: I'm not theirs. I'm nobody's.

At the far end of the carriage the choirboy turns a page. It is the same page.

Farmhouses with roofs almost to the ground, an onion-spired church. High on the hill, a square black tower and a broken wall.

Dec: Ah, God.

Inès: I told you to bring boots.

Dec: I'm from Galway. We don't have weather. We have rain.

The young man in grey walks past close enough to touch. As his coat swings, Dec sees the round edge of a watch in the waistcoat pocket.

He walks up the single street, turns in at a gate, and is gone.

Woodsmoke, melted cheese and wet dog. An old Bernese mountain dog asleep on the hearth. Inès gives it a wide berth anyway.

Inès: Two rooms. Please.

Madame Jobin: Of course! On your honeymoon? Everyone comes to the plateau on honeymoon. It's the quiet.

Inès: No.

Madame Jobin: Rooms three and four. They have a door between. It locks. From both sides.

She winks at Dec. The dog opens one eye at him with enormous pity and closes it again.

Madame Jobin: And nobody goes up to the priory in winter. Two metres on the track. If it's the tower you want, ask Mère Clothilde at the museum. She knows everything up there.

High on the hill, a small light moves through the ruin. It goes behind the broken wall. Then it climbs slowly, as if carried up a stair inside the tower, and rests near the top.

It burns there, steady and patient, the way the chalk was patient.

At exactly nine o'clock by Dec's phone, it goes out.

Dec: Somebody's up there right now. We could follow the tracks while they're fresh.

Inès: In trainers. At night. Into two metres of snow, after a man who stops clocks.

Dec: Or we trust a woman who thinks we're on honeymoon, and wait for a nun.

Inès: She was right about the snow. I'll take her word on the nun.

Dec: And the fella in grey knows where we're sleeping.

Inès looks at the dark where the light was. Then at the door between the rooms, and its lock.

Find Mère Clothilde's museum in the morning - turn to section 13.

5



The white quilt, Roux's drawings, the tray. The cup is half empty.

Dec: Cloves. Cloves and slate.

Roux, in his head, a bit deaf and very angry: everything tastes of cloves. Dec sets the cup down with great care. Then he crosses the room in two strides, sticks two fingers down his throat and is sick into Madame Jobin's geraniums, thoroughly. He will later call it professional.

He kneels by the window, eyes streaming. His head feels light,

like after the second pint. The tea or the fear, he can't tell.

Dec: Whoever left that tray is coming back. To see if it worked. To do the clocks.

He looks at the pot, still nearly full. Five seconds.

He pours it down the sink, all but a finger's depth. He half fills the cup with water and leaves it where a man would who drank half and fell asleep. He eats both biscuits, because that man would have.

Then he lies down on the quilt, facing the door, one arm hanging off the bed, eyes almost shut.

Twice the room tilts, gently, like a boat, and tilts back. He bites the inside of his cheek.

The key turns in the lock.

Calm and attentive, almost kind, like a nurse on his rounds. He looks into the cup, then the pot, and nods to himself.

Then he goes to work, quick and silent, like a man laying a table he has laid a hundred times. Dec's watch, set to 09:00. The travel clock, stopped at nine, a sliver of brass pushed into the movement. The cuckoo clock by the door, set to nine from a chair, its pendulum wedged.

Then he picks up Dec's phone.

Dec's heart stops, and starts again twice as fast.

The phone is locked. Fabien takes Dec's hand gently, the way you'd take a child's, and presses his thumb to the button. It

opens.

He scrolls the photographs without a flicker, deletes them, empties the deleted folder, and sets the phone's clock to nine.

Last, he opens the wardrobe, takes out a stick of chalk and draws on the bare pine inside the door with his head on one side.

At the door he looks back at Dec, and his lips move. Latin, very quiet. A prayer, perhaps. For Dec, or for himself.

The key turns. Dec lies staring at the chalk, so angry he can no longer feel his hands.

Dec counts sixty, climbs out over the geraniums and slides off the porch roof into a snowdrift. It is not a rooftop chase. He will be firm about that afterwards.

Fabien walks up the street openly, past the lit windows of the workshops, to a small dark house at the edge of the forest. Smoke from the chimney. A big black four-by-four outside.

Dec: The bald man. He didn't take the train. He drove.

Fabien stops by the woodpile and makes a call, low and respectful, a junior clerk to a senior partner. Dec crouches behind a stack of logs ten metres away.

Fabien: Yes, the Irishman. Half the pot at least. He'll sleep until tomorrow night. The photographs are gone. I saw to it.

Fabien: The woman is at the museum with the old nun. She'll find him in the morning. She'll find the chalk.

Fabien: And Morel? He'll have the word by Sunday? Good. And then... yes. Of course. As the rule says.

Behind the logs, Dec goes cold all over again.

Fabien: The guests. The minister. The prefect, yes, he's confirmed. Two bankers from the Bourse, the journalist from the television, the cardinal's secretary.

Fabien: The catering is ours. The wine at half past two, half an hour before None. They'll wake remembering the eclipse, the clocks stopping and your voice. Only that. And they'll tell it on camera, all the same way. A miracle.

For the first time, there is warmth in his voice.

Fabien: And the Seventh will collect. Nine minutes of every signal in Paris, the markets in a panic. The fund's positions are... Forgive me. Not my concern.

Fabien: The train worked beautifully. I got off at Saignelégier and our brother drove me up. They walked straight in. Mutuo datum, Brother.

He hangs up. Dec shifts to ease his cramp, and the German geologist's boot slips off a frozen log. The top of the stack rolls into the snow, knock, knock, knock.

Fabien's head comes round.

Five stone steps down, and a smell so thick Dec could lean on it. In the grey light from a grating, rows of tall round cheeses ripen in perfect silence.

A torch beam comes down the steps. Over the cheeses. Over

the wet flagstones. It stops a metre from his knees, on his footprints. Then it goes away.

Fabien: Rien. Cheese.

A grunt. A very large, very low grunt.

The door shuts. A wooden bar drops across it outside, clunk. The four-by-four coughs into life and its lights sweep away down the valley.

Dec: Locked in. Again. That's three times this week. That's a personal best.

The cheeses don't reply. A bar on the outside. On the inside, no handle, no keyhole.

Dec: At least it's not minus twenty. It's about minus two, though. I'm going to die in a cheese cave, and they'll put that on my headstone in Galway.

An engine, old and clattering, a fan belt screaming on the corners. Boots crunch. The bar lifts, the door opens, and Dec falls backwards into the snow.

Dec: How did you...

Inès: I went to your room to tell you about the page. Chalk in your wardrobe. Sick in Madame Jobin's geraniums. Your window open.

Inès: Footprints from the window, up the street, to the logs, into here. Your feet are very easy to follow. They're very big.

Dec: They know we know, Inès. And they've wiped my phone.

Clothilde: Get in the van. Arguing in the snow is for Protestants.

Cheese crates and diesel. Clothilde takes the hairpins far too fast for the night train to Basel.

He tells her everything, down to the wine at half past two, and Morel, and as the rule says.

Inès: Your phone's wiped. Mine isn't.

Inès: Mine had four per cent in the tower. Before it died I took the ledger, the REMIT page and the list of tests. Vincennes, the quai de la Rapée, Austerlitz.

Inès: Not the flyleaf. Not the Panthéon page. Those were on yours. It's not enough.

Dec: It's not nothing.

The van swings round a hairpin. The crates slide, and she slides with them against him, and stays.

Dec: I was frightened. When he took my hand to open the phone. I've never been so frightened in my life.

Inès says something in Hungarian, low and quick.

Dec: What does that mean?

Inès: Nothing. It's Hungarian. It doesn't count.

In the dark her hand finds the sleeve of his jacket, and holds on all the way down the mountain.

Go back to Paris and face Morel - turn to section 3.

6



Orange street light, wet brambles, a black cutting below. Somewhere a dog barks and Inès flinches.

La Taupe looks Dec up and down.

La Taupe: Too tall.

Dec: I'm what?

La Taupe: For the galleries. One metre forty in spots. You'll crack your skull and moan. The tall ones always moan.

La Taupe: Your mother's hairdresser says you're afraid of

everything.

Inès: Not everything. Heights. Dogs.

La Taupe: Underground there's no heights and no dogs. Only water and the dead. You're fine with the dead?

Inès: I restore paintings from the sixteen hundreds. Everyone in them is dead.

La Taupe considers this, and seems to find it acceptable.

La Taupe: Bon. Waders.

She pulls two pairs from the backpack. They smell powerfully of old rubber.

La Taupe: Headlamps. If you lose me, stand still and shout. If you don't stand still, I find you in three weeks and you won't be interesting any more.

Dec hops into his waders and catches Inès's eye.

Dec: Your mother's hairdresser has a very complete family.

Black brick, dripping. A hundred metres in, a low gap half hidden by rubble. La Taupe lies on her back and slides into it feet first, like a letter into a postbox.

Inès goes next, because if she thinks about it she won't.

A crawl through yellow rock opens into a gallery as tall as a church nave. Pale limestone sweating with damp, black water round their ankles.

La Taupe: The street above us. They dug out the stone to build Paris, and every gallery is named for the street on top.

Up there, someone's eating a kebab.

Behind them Dec crawls out, stands up, and hits his head on a ceiling exactly as tall as he is not.

Dec: Ow. No, it's fine. It's grand. I'm not complaining.

La Taupe: He's complaining.

Inès: He's Irish. It's how they say thank you.

They walk for an hour. Inès loses her sense of direction in ten minutes. La Taupe talks the whole way.

La Taupe: Spinoza was badly treated by everyone. Including Spinoza.

La Taupe: And drainage. Nobody respects drainage. It's the most important art in Paris.

Dec: Is that you and Spinoza on the drainage side, or...

La Taupe: Turn left.

They wade to the knees twice. In one gallery Dec has to turn sideways and hold his breath, and not one complaint comes out of him. Inès finds herself almost sorry.

The walls change. Long brown bones stacked like firewood, ends outward, and set into the stack at chest height a row of skulls, all looking the same way.

La Taupe: The overflow. When they emptied the old cemeteries, the tourist part filled up. The rest went wherever there was room. The old tollgate's right above us.

Inès has cleaned the faces of martyrs and a Flemish field of

plague dead. This is different. The skulls all face one way, patient, as if waiting for a bus.

Dec: Niches. Look.

Along the walls of bone, at intervals, arched hollows a metre high, each with a stone sill. Some hold a scratched cross. One holds a jam jar with a dead flower in it.

Inès: The ninth niche.

They count. La Taupe counts with them out loud, in French, as if counting sheep.

La Taupe: …sept, huit, neuf.

The ninth is empty. No cross, no jar. Smooth stone sill, smooth sides, a back wall of yellow limestone.

Dec puts his hand flat on the back wall and moves it slowly, the way Inès runs her fingertips over a canvas to feel where the paint changes. He stops. He pushes.

Deep in the rock, something goes clunk, like a big key turning in a big door. The back of the niche swings inward.

La Taupe: Oh, putain.

For the first time tonight she sounds about twelve.

A round room cut from the rock, the size of the atelier, under a low dome. The floor is dry and swept. Nine tall empty niches stand round the walls, each with a little stone step in front, like a place for a person to stand.

On the altar, on a wooden stand, lies a ledger bound in leather

the colour of dried blood.

Inès goes to it before she can think, and turns the pages with the end of her pencil, as in an archive.

Inès: The first half is old. Brown ink, the hands changing every few pages. Horae solutae. Heures payées. Hours paid.

Inès: The second half is new. Black ink. One neat hand. And a different heading.

And under it, the ink so new it still seems wet:

Inès: The judge. The bookseller. The curate. Roux. Pichon's four cases.

Inès: And Lassalle. No hour after his name. Just remis. Delivered. Returned. Paid off.

Dec: Somebody wrote him off. In a book. Like a bill.

At the bottom of the page, set apart from the names, a note in the same neat hand.

Inès: By the rule of the Debt Clock. Brother Anselm Vey. The Priory of Combe-Noire, in the Jura.

Inès: Vey. The man who made Roux's lock. Roux said it: Vey kept the word in his book.

La Taupe: Inès. Lamps off. Now.

Far off down the galleries, getting nearer: footsteps in water. Many of them, slow and even.

And voices, low, rising and falling. It takes Inès a breath to understand. They are chanting.

La Taupe: There's nowhere to run. Only the niches. The one behind the altar is deepest. In, all of us, and not a sound.

La Taupe: The cataphiles who see things down here are the ones they never find.

A light flickers far down the gallery. Candles, moving in pairs.

Dec stays where he is, eyes on the ledger: Roux's name, and the word after Lassalle's.

Dec: Whoever wrote that is about to walk through that door. And we'd be in a hole, in the dark, not even knowing his face.

Dec: Roux said silver hair. A voice like warm oil. A watch with no hands. One look under the hood and we'd have a face to give Pichon.

La Taupe: One look and they look back. I know these galleries. You don't.

La Taupe: Keep that lamp on and you're on your own. I don't wait for anybody.

Inès: Dec.

Dec: Tell me to switch it off and I will.

The footsteps reach the bone wall outside. The candlelight finds the edge of the open stone door.

Inès's thumb is on the switch of her headlamp. Dec's lamp is still burning, pointed at the door.

She has known La Taupe for one hour. She has known Dec for three days.

Trust La Taupe: lamps off and into the niche - turn to section 4.

Keep the lamps on and see the face under the hood - turn to section 14.

7



A stone spiral barely wider than her shoulders. A greasy rope for a handrail. On the inner side, a hand's-width gap and darkness dropping away.

She doesn't look down. She counts, the way she counted Vey's wheels. One step, one number.

Inès: Forty-one. Forty-two.

By a hundred the stair has begun to tilt. She presses her forehead to cold stone and shuts her eyes.

Inès: Basszus. Basszus. Basszus.

At nine she froze on the first landing of a tower in Lyon. Her father sat beside her, sang a long song about a horse, asked: up or down? She said down.

Inès: I'm not nine.

She opens her eyes and climbs.

A narrow stone ring, a waist-high balustrade, sixty metres of darkening air below. The pendulum's sphere a pinhead. The steel cable rises past her to the crown; from the crown a second cable, black and new, runs down the dome's ribs.

A hum she feels in her teeth.

Vaulmont: ...and when the light is taken from us, my friends, we will see what we truly owe...

She walks to it with her hand on the wall, giving the drop nothing. Roux's wheels are crisp, perfect. She steadies her wrist, as for gold leaf on a halo, and turns the first.

Behind her, from the south stair, footsteps.

He comes on slowly, the way you follow a cat you don't want to frighten into the road. She backs away round the ring, shaking from her teeth to her knees.

Vaulmont: ...nine minutes, my friends. Only nine. The hour of None...

Below, a hundred voices gasp. Outside, thousands. A long rising sigh, like wind through trees.

The light goes out.

The dome turns a deep glowing blue, the inside of a mussel shell, a ring of pale fire in the windows.

Through the great doors, the traffic lights of the rue Soufflot flash red again.

Vaulmont: Mutuo datum. Reddetur.

Something explodes into her face. Wings, dust. Her hip hits the balustrade; for one endless second there is nothing on her right but blue dark. Then she is on her knees, arms round a baluster.

For a few seconds the sixty metres vanish. Something is more frightened than she is. She folds its wings under her palm and works the mesh free. Her hand shakes. The bird lets her.

Kessler has stopped two metres away, his head turned toward the bird. She holds it out to him in both hands, palm up, the way he held out his hand for the notebook in the tower.

His hands are very warm. He stands with the bird against his chest, still as a man in church, and she walks past him. Then she runs.

At the far stairhead a torch beam swings up out of the arch, and Dec behind it, gasping.

Dec: Inès!

Inès: The cabinet! It's Roux's lock. You can't pick it. Use the word!

The torch finds the nine wheels. And behind Dec, coming up out of the same arch, unhurried, a small dark pistol in one gloved hand: Vaulmont.

Inès doesn't stop. A low iron door in the east pier opens on a conservators' stair, down to the nave, the microphone, the painting.

Inès: You look at the door. I look at the painting.

She takes the steps two at a time into the dark.

Vaulmont: Monsieur Hartley. Please don't touch that. Monsieur Roux is a genius, and a very rude one. You could be there with your picks until Easter.

Dec: Yeah. I noticed.

Vaulmont: In four minutes the debt is called. Afterwards nothing bad will happen to you. We are not monsters. We simply keep accounts.

Dec doesn't step away. When he's frightened, he talks.

Dec: Can I tell you something about locks? My da used to say every lock's a story about what somebody's afraid of.

Behind his back his fingers find the first wheel. Already on R. The second: four, from B. They went over the offsets thirty times at the bench.

Dec: This one's a monk in a plague. Built a whole religion on everyone owing everyone. And he's terrified. Of his own bill.

Dec: So he puts in his lock the one word he wants and doesn't

think he'll get. And you lot keep his nine numbers six hundred years like a relic.

Third wheel. Fourth. Fifth.

Dec: And not one banker or bishop among you ever counted round the letters.

Vaulmont: What are you doing?

Dec: Opening it. With the word.

Vaulmont: There is no word. There are numbers. The Rule...

Dec: Seventh. Eighth. All those people, to find a word that was in your lock the whole time.

Dec: It's not pay, Monsieur de Vaulmont.

He turns the ninth wheel.

Dec: It's forgive.

A small, deep, perfect click. The brass doors swing open an inch, the hum comes out loud, the green light.

He turns it, hard, all the way round, until it clunks. The green lights go out down the rack. Silence fills the dome.

Vaulmont stares at the wheels. His lips move, spelling the word letter by letter, like a child.

Below, the traffic lights of the rue Soufflot turn green. The FONDATION VAULMONT clock lurches, sweeps round, stops.

Two minutes short of None. A puzzled murmur goes through the nave: people promised a miracle, watching it tidy itself

away.

Then a woman's voice comes out of the loudspeakers.

Far below, in the TV light, a small figure in a mustard scarf pulls the cloth off the painting and holds photograph twenty-three to the camera.

Inès: My name is Inès Varga. I restore this painting. This is their founder's last line. Someone scraped one word out. I've put it back.

Inès: Mutuo datum remittere hora nona. What was given as a loan, forgive at the ninth hour.

Inès: And the clocks were not a miracle. There's a transmitter in the dome, built by the Fondation Vaulmont. Someone has just turned it off.

Inès: The wine you drank at half past two was meant to hold datura. It was swapped. The real wine is in a crate in the south transept.

In the silence, sixty metres up, Dec hears the pendulum go past.

The minister, empty pewter cup in hand, begins to laugh helplessly. The prefect has gone the colour of a church candle. The camera's red light stays on.

Dec turns. Vaulmont has lowered the pistol.

Vaulmont: Forgive. Six hundred years.

Dec: Yeah. Funny old thing.

Vaulmont looks at him with enormous patience, like a man considering a bill. Then he turns the pistol round and holds it out, butt first. Dec takes it like a dead fish.

Vaulmont: I'll go down by the stair. You'll forgive me if I don't wait for you.

The light returns as a long silver dawn. Outside, the crowd cheers, a little embarrassed by its relief.

Pichon: Auguste de Vaulmont. I'm arresting you for the murder of Gérard Lassalle.

Pichon: And for poisoning Anselme Roux, Judge Delorme, Madame Aubry, the Abbé Girardin and Jean-Paul Morel. All alive, I'm happy to say, and very angry.

Pichon: You like to keep accounts. So do I.

Kessler comes out of the south stair with his hands empty and holds out his great wrists to the nearest officer, who goes white.

From the south transept, a crash, a yelp, a delighted young voice.

Moussa: Monsieur l'agent! The thin one tried to take the crate. I'm sitting on him. Do you want him?

A young officer takes the pistol from Dec's fingers like scissors from a child. The pendulum swings past, and back. It never stopped. It kept its own plane while the city turned underneath.

He lifts his hand, a little, uncertain.

After a moment, so slightly nobody else in the Panthéon would see it, she lifts hers.

Wake up on Thursday and count the clocks - turn to section 12
.

8



The white quilt, Roux's drawings, the tray on the bed.

Dec: Spiced. The Swiss put cloves in everything. Roux said something about cloves. Roux says a lot of things.

Dec: It's the cold. That's all it is.

He drinks it down. His bones are still cold from the tower, so he pours a second and drinks that too.

Then the room tilts. Gently. Like a boat leaving a quay.

He puts the cup on the drawings and misses. Tea runs across

Vey's nine wheels. He watches it soak in and can't think why it matters.

He lies back on the quilt. The ceiling is miles away.

A key turns in the lock. It sounds like it's in another building.

Dec sees him in pieces, the way you see a street from a train. A hand on a pot. A chair dragged to the cuckoo clock. His own wrist lifted, his watch turned on it, set down again.

Dec: Wha... who...

The words come out in the wrong order and lie down.

Fabien: Shh. It's all right, Monsieur Hartley.

Cool fingers press Dec's thumb to his phone. Then the wardrobe creaks, and somebody is drawing on wood.

At the door Fabien turns, kind and earnest.

Fabien: You owe a day, that's all. Everyone does. Mutuo datum.

The door closes. Dec means to get up. He means it hard. He watches the ceiling go soft at the edges until it's the moon.

Inès knocked last night at ten and again at eleven, and got nothing. After the tower she thought he was avoiding her. She thought that was fair.

This morning Madame Jobin hands her the key without a single honeymoon joke.

Dec: There you are. Is it Saturday? I've to meet you for breakfast. We're going to talk about the weather.

Inès: Dec. Show me your tongue.

He does, as obliging as a boy at the doctor's.

She reads the room the way she reads a painting, one thing at a time. The travel clock says nine. The cuckoo says nine. Tea has dried brown on Roux's drawings. The wardrobe door stands ajar.

She picks up his phone. The photographs from the tower are gone, every one, and the phone's clock says 09:00.

Inès: Basszus.

Dec: Have I done something?

Inès: No. Somebody has.

She runs the whole way in the wrong boots. Clothilde said the young man in grey rented it.

Tyre tracks show where the black four-by-four stood, already filling with fresh snow. Inside: a cold stove, a swept floor, a smell of candle wax. Nothing else.

She brought him home on the Sunday night train, his head on her shoulder. Every hour he asked whether they were nearly at Saturday.

The big easel is empty. A docket on the bench says the Fondation's courier took the Allegory on Friday, while they were in the snow. Morel signed for it.

Morel hasn't answered his phone since Sunday. The atelier is hers now, and the sofa, and the man on it.

On her own phone she has the REMIT page and the list of tests, saved before it died in the tower.

The Panthéon line she has only in her head. She read it over Dec's shoulder by his torch, the night the trap banged shut, and said it aloud: five kilometres.

A restorer remembering a notebook she no longer has. Nobody will believe that, and she knows it.

At ten an email comes.

Inès reads the last line four times. She puts the phone face down on the bench and doesn't touch it again until morning.

The skylight has gone a strange thin grey, like light through a dirty window. On the bench, her laptop shows the live broadcast from the Panthéon.

Dec: Is that your painting?

Inès: Yes.

Dec: It's lovely. When did they take it?

Inès: While we were in the snow.

Waiters move along the front row with little pewter cups. The minister drinks. The prefect drinks. A banker raises his cup to the camera.

Dec: Mulled wine. In April. Your man's very fancy.

By a quarter to three the front row has gone soft. Heads tilt. A journalist smiles at nothing. Inès knows that smile. She has watched it on Dec for four days, and now she knows what was

in the cups.

Nobody on the broadcast seems to notice.

Above them, the skylight dims to blue. The light drains from the room as if someone were drawing it off with a cloth.

On the laptop the nave goes dark. Phones light up in it like fireflies.

Down in the rue Vieille-du-Temple a car horn starts, then another, and they don't stop.

On the screen a tall man stands at the lectern, silver hair swept back, perfectly calm. The camera loves him.

Vaulmont: Do not be afraid. The debt is called. For nine minutes, my friends, we will know what we owe.

Vaulmont: Mutuo datum. Reddetur.

Behind him, in the dark, the pendulum swings past and back, and nobody stops anything.

At three the light comes back, silver and slow. The clocks lurch and start. In the front row the minister lifts his head, tears on his face, and tells the camera he saw the hand of God.

Dec: Inès. What day is it?

She looks at the skylight, and the laptop, and the man on the sofa who once told her a twenty-minute story about a cat called Pádraig to keep her alive.

Inès: It's later than that.

From her bench drawer she takes an old steel watch with a

cracked strap. Zoltán's. She winds it, twelve slow turns, the way her father did at red lights. Then she takes off Dec's stopped watch and buckles her father's on in its place.

It ticks. He holds it to his ear and smiles, as if she has given him the time.

Dec loses his day and the city loses nine minutes

The End.

Turn to section 1 to start again.

9



A trolley of three wooden crates, stencilled FRAGILE and CECI N'EST PAS UNE BOMBE. It seemed funny in the workshop in February.

Dec: Escape room. For the guests. Pour s'amuser.

Dec: The stencil's a joke. Magritte? The pipe?

Nobody wants to argue about Magritte at seven in the morning. The guard waves him through.

Pale stone, columns like oak trees, a dome so high its saints

are the size of thumbnails. From the crown a steel cable comes down sixty-seven metres to a brass sphere swinging above a brass ring.

Beside it stand a low grey stage, a lectern, and an easel under grey cloth.

They look at each other across the nave. Neither moves. The pendulum swings between them, and back.

His room: stone-effect walls, a bench of brass gears, a real iron lock. On the wall, a clock with nine hours on its face. The client's brief asked for it. He thought it was a quirk.

Through the hatch in his planks he reaches the old iron grille. Its lock takes nine minutes. He can't stop counting in nines.

The bolt goes back. He leaves the grille closed but unlocked, and puts the hatch back.

Dec: Nobody'll need it. But it's there.

A hard blue sky, but the light has gone wrong, every shadow thin and slightly blue. Outside, hundreds hold up cardboard eclipse glasses.

Inside: a tall tired minister, the prefect of police in silver braid, two bankers in navy, a priest with a purple sash, a presenter with a famous tan.

Everyone Vaulmont speaks to walks away a little straighter, as if something has been lent to them.

She doesn't look at Dec. That's the arrangement. Once, as the pendulum swings between them, her eyes meet his and go

back to her clipboard.

Agency waiters, young and bored. At the back table, a man in a white jacket that doesn't suit him, with a narrow back Dec would know anywhere.

Steel urns of ordinary vin chaud. And apart, four pewter jugs of something almost brown, with a grey sheen like the bloom on a plum.

The whole chapel smells of cloves.

Dec turns away before Fabien can turn round, and walks straight into a waiter with a tray of spoons.

Moussa: Pardon, monsieur. Ça va? You're white.

Dec: I'm Irish. We're always white.

Dec: Moussa. The brown wine in the pewter. When does it go out?

Moussa: Half past two. Only the guests on his list. Any waiter who drinks it is sacked.

Moussa: It smells like a church at Christmas. This morning I saw him tip something into the jugs from a paper bag. Grey, like ash.

Dec: It's a drug. It makes you lose a day, and remember only what you're told.

Dec: Then the minister and the prefect say it on the telly.

Dec: I need to swap the jugs and keep the real ones for the police. I can't do it on my own.

Moussa: How much do you think I'm paid for this?

Dec: Not enough.

Moussa: Eleven euros forty an hour. Before tax. And he shouted at Fatou for folding the napkins wrong.

Moussa: What do you need?

A crate stencilled CECI N'EST PAS UNE BOMBE stands by the wall. Moussa knocks it over with great force and theatrical surprise.

Four hundred brass gears burst out and ring across the stone, like all the coins in the world dropped at once.

Every waiter goes down on hands and knees. For forty seconds every eye is on the floor.

Dec builds rooms where forty seconds is a whole puzzle.

Behind the screen, the four pewter jugs go into the empty crate. In their place go four jugs of Moussa's vin chaud, a spoonful of cocoa stirred into each. Brown-grey and dull. Under a lid, it will do.

Dec shuts the crate and sits on it.

Fabien stands up with his hands full of brass. The jugs are where they always were. Moussa apologises at length, in French and Wolof.

The silver trays go out. The guests on the list look at the little clock on the cup, smile, and drink.

Across the nave, Vaulmont's calm face relaxes very slightly,

like a man hearing the last wheel of a lock fall into place.

Dec's phone buzzes.

He types without looking.

A second later:

The sun is a thin sickle behind the moon. The light drains as if someone is turning down a dimmer on Paris.

Vaulmont: Time is not ours.

The voice fills the nave. Warm oil, poured slowly.

Vaulmont: Every hour of every life is lent. Today, for a few minutes, the light that measures our hours will be taken away.

Vaulmont: And we will stand together in the dark, and remember it was never ours to keep.

Up the south aisle comes a thin pale figure in a white jacket, scanning the columns.

The narrow face finds his and stays blank. Fabien's lips move, into the earpiece.

At the foot of the roped stair, Kessler's great bald head turns slowly toward the south aisle.

Dec can't go up now. Every step he takes, two men will take with him.

He looks across the nave for Inès. She has already put her clipboard down on the easel.

Inès walks the north aisle without hurrying, in her green

dress and mustard scarf. Nobody watches a woman with a clipboard, or notices she has left it behind.

Behind it is the other stair, the service stair inside the wall: sixty metres round and round, a greasy rope for a handrail and nothing on the other side.

It is the stair she is most afraid of.

Up there, where the pendulum cable meets the crown, waits the transmitter from Morel's notebook.

She looks back once and finds Dec behind his column. He can't nod. Fabien is watching him.

Inès: Basszus.

She puts her hand on the rope and looks up into the dark.

Climb toward the dome - turn to section 7.

10



One lamp on the bench. Orange cloud sits in the skylight. Inès's notebook lies open under the lamp.

Pichon's name glows on the screen. Dec's thumb hovers. He turns the phone face down on the cushion.

Dec: No uniforms. We agreed.

Inès: We agreed.

She has what the tower left on her phone, and what the Jura left in her notebook.

Inès: Nine ticks. Five letters in Vey's own hand. Four to go, and the last is an E or an L.

She rings Les Bréviaires. Clothilde picks up on the second ring. A television mutters behind her.

Clothilde: The honeymoon that isn't. Is he alive?

Inès: Asleep on a sofa. Ma Mère, I need a word. Nine letters. REMIT, then three I can't read, and the last is an E.

Clothilde: The sisters always said Vey repented at the end. A lender who repents does only one thing, child.

Clothilde: Remittere. He lets the debt go. We say it at every absolution. In remissionem peccatorum.

Inès writes it under the ticks. It fits, letter for letter, down to the flat foot of the E.

Inès: Mutuo datum remittere hora nona. What was given as a loan, forgive at the ninth hour.

Clothilde: And they scraped it off. Of course they did. Bankers.

Clothilde: Inès. Drink nothing they pour you.

She hangs up. Dec is sitting up, hair flat on one side.

Dec: You did that with a phone call.

Inès: Clothilde did it with a prayer. Don't make a thing of it.

His phone buzzes against the cushion.

Dec: He wants me inside. Grand. Galerie du dôme, the notebook said. That's the walk round the outside, on every

tourist map.

Fabien wiped the photograph. But Inès read that line over Dec's shoulder in the tower, by his torch, and said it out loud. She has said it to herself every night since.

Inès: Wait.

She opens the list of tests on her phone, all she kept of Morel's notebook.

Inès: Every test reaches further. Jean-Paul checked the range. On long wave, range means a long wire, hung high.

In Morel's drawer of gift-shop rubbish she finds a postcard of the Panthéon.

Inès: Sixty-seven metres of steel, hanging free in the middle of Paris. It isn't only a pendulum, Dec. It's an aerial.

Inès: Not the gallery outside. The one inside, at the top, where the cable hangs from.

Dec: Then I swap the wine at half past two, the way Fabien said on the phone. And then I go up with the word.

The cell in the crypt is finished, and with the pass nobody stops him.

Kessler fills the arch of the roped south stair. The narrow north stair inside the wall has a new chain and a shiny brass padlock.

Dec: Two minutes, that. Later, when nobody's looking.

The CECI N'EST PAS UNE BOMBE crate goes over with

theatrical surprise. Four hundred gears ring across the stone like all the coins in the world.

Behind the screen, four pewter jugs of the real wine go into the empty crate. Four jugs of vin chaud with a spoon of cocoa take their place.

Moussa: Eleven euros forty an hour. For this, I want twelve.

At half past two the trays go out. The minister drinks. The prefect drinks. The cardinal's secretary asks for a second cup.

Dec watches them drink harmless wine and breathes out. Then he walks to the north aisle, not hurrying.

Vaulmont's voice fills the nave behind him. Everyone is facing the stage.

Vaulmont: ...and when the light is taken from us, my friends, we will see what we truly owe...

Seventy seconds. The shackle drops, and he goes up into the dark two steps at a time, the word ready in his mouth.

By the easel, Inès feels a hum in her back teeth. It comes down the steel cable from the dome, and the brass sphere carries it past her.

Inès: Go on, Dec. Go on.

Forty steps up, a torch hits him from below.

Not police. The prefect's own protection detail, who answer to the man in the front row and not to any commissaire. They have just watched a contractor pick a lock twenty metres

from a minister.

Dec: There's a radio up there! On the cable! Two minutes, I only need two minutes!

They don't need two minutes. They need four seconds, and one of them twists his wrist until the picks fall.

They are marching him down the north aisle when the light goes. The dome turns deep blue, and outside thousands of people sigh at once.

Phones light up all over the nave, every screen at 09:00. Through the great doors the traffic lights of the rue Soufflot flash red.

And the guests see it, wide awake and sober, cups in their hands. They will remember every second, because Dec made sure of it.

The minister stands up. The cardinal's secretary crosses himself.

Vaulmont: Do not be afraid. For nine minutes the city will hear its debt. Mutuo datum.

Vaulmont: Reddetur.

Dec: It's a radio! It's a box in the dome! It's a radio!

Dec: Inès! Tell them!

Inès: Nobody's listening.

At three the light comes back, silver and slow. Vaulmont lifts one hand, and the station clock lurches round to three.

Vaulmont: And now, my friends, it is given back.

The nave stands and applauds. Some of them are weeping. The camera's red light stays on.

Two hundred clocks are ticking, every one of them right.

Roux: LE MIRACLE DU PANTHÉON. Front page. With a photograph of a clock.

Roux: The Bourse lost billions in nine minutes. And somebody, it says here, has made billions.

Roux: Nom de Dieu de nom de Dieu. It's a radio. I told him I wouldn't build it.

Inès: Somebody else did.

Roux: Where's the Irishman?

Inès: The prefecture let him go at six this morning. Monsieur de Vaulmont declined to press charges.

Inès: A foreigner, overexcited by an eclipse. He told them he'd hate to spoil such a beautiful day.

The easel is empty. Dec sits on the sofa, a bruise coming up on one wrist.

A courier has left two envelopes: one cream, one with a bank's blue logo.

Clipped to it is a cheque: the fee for the Clockmaker's Cell, exactly as Dec invoiced it, to the cent.

Dec: He paid me. And he let me go.

Inès: Of course he did. He keeps accounts.

She opens the blue envelope.

Inès: He's called in the atelier. My bench, my lamps, Jean-Paul's sofa. Nine days.

Dec: Your painting?

Inès: Lent to the Panthéon, it says in the paper. By popular demand.

On her bench, under the lamp, her notebook still lies open at one word in pencil. REMITTERE.

She closes it.

The miracle succeeds on live television

The End.

Turn to section 1 to start again.

11



Fourth floor of a glass building. On the desk, an andouillette that smells like a farmyard that has been through something.

Dec tells him everything, from the chapel to Vincennes. Pichon stops chewing only once, at the Seventh will collect. Inès puts her phone and a memory stick on the desk. He reads one photograph twice.

Pichon: Morel is at the Hôtel-Dieu. He doesn't know his name. Datura, much more than the others. He may come back. He may not.

Pichon: And Lassalle. Datura in the blood, water in the lungs. He was alive when he went into the Seine. Marks on his arms where two hands held him. Large hands.

Dec: And?

Pichon: On Sunday the prefect's office telephoned. Very politely. The prefect expects the heart attack to be confirmed.

Pichon: He'll be at the vigil, as guest of a friend. Whose foundation complains of an Irishman trespassing in Switzerland.

Pichon: Your name is on a list, Monsieur Hartley. Not my list. Theirs.

Dec: So what happens now?

Pichon folds his napkin.

Pichon: Now I arrest you.

Twenty officers at twenty desks.

Pichon: Declan Hartley. You are under arrest for obstruction of a criminal inquiry. Stand up.

Inès: Commissaire, that is not...

Pichon: Sit down, Madame Varga, or you will join him.

He walks Dec slowly past every desk. By the lifts, a man in a good suit who doesn't look like a policeman holds a coffee, watches them go by, and takes out his phone.

In the lift Pichon lets go of his arm and watches the numbers go down, his face grey and old.

A bench, a steel toilet, frosted glass. A steel door with a card reader. No keyhole.

Dec: I hate this building.

Pichon: Everybody does. It was designed by a man who had never been arrested. I'm sorry for upstairs.

Pichon: The man by the lifts is the prefect's. For perhaps a day, they'll think I know which way the wind blows.

Pichon: On paper you were released at one. I'll sign after my dessert.

Dec: You believe us.

Pichon: I believed you on the first day. When you told me about the tongue.

Pichon: But if I go upstairs with photographs of a notebook I don't have and a sermon about a monk, they take my badge. Then there's no one.

He holds out a folded sheet of paper.

Pichon: A police officer reads a great many boring documents. Sometimes he leaves them lying about.

Pichon: The pendulum hangs from the crown of the dome. Sixty-seven metres of cable. A fine thing to hang other things from, if one were a radio amateur from Brittany.

Pichon: I know nothing about radios. I know about lunch. There's a tarte Tatin in the canteen, and I've had a difficult morning. Mind the door. It's heavy.

His shoes go away up the stairs. The steel door stands wide open, its card reader blinking. Dec had very nearly worked that reader out.

Dec: That's not fair. I'd have had that.

Inès: The pendulum cable. It's a sixty-seven-metre aerial hanging in the middle of Paris.

Dec: And I'm on a list. If the prefecture sees me near the Panthéon on Wednesday, I'm done.

His phone buzzes. He reads the email and starts to laugh, quite helplessly.

Inès: He wants you there.

Dec: Where he can see me. In the crypt, in a little room I built with a door that locks, while he's up under the dome with his radio.

Dec: Nobody arrests a man Vaulmont put on his own guest list. The pass is the trap, and it's the door. And I know every way out of that room. I drew them.

One lamp on the bench, orange cloud in the skylight. Dec is asleep on the green sofa with his boots on, talking.

Dec: Ah, Mrs Kilbride, sure it's no trouble.

Under the lamp: photograph twenty-three, her notebook, the REMIT page, Roux's drawings.

Inès: Ne csak nézd, lásd. Don't just look. See.

Inès: Not decoration. A table. Count round each wheel from

its own first letter.

She counts like stitches. Seventeen on the first wheel: R. Four on the second, which starts at B: E.

The ninth gate has no number. Only a blank square, and Roux's furious biro.

She turns to photograph twenty-three. Nine ghost ticks, and at the foot of the ninth a short flat stroke. E or L. No word ends remitterl.

Inès: To send back. To let go. To forgive a debt.

Inès: Mutuo datum remittere hora nona. What was given as a loan, to forgive at the ninth hour.

Inès: Not reddetur. Not repaid. Vey wrote the other word, and made it the word for his lock.

Inès: Their own lock says forgive. And in six hundred years they never counted round the letters.

She takes off her glasses, presses her hands to her eyes, and puts them back. Then she kicks the sofa.

Dec: Wha'? Mrs Kilbride? What?

Inès: Get up. I've got the word.

Dec: That's mad. You did that with a pencil.

Inès: Don't make a thing of it.

Dec: And Roux's copy, up in the dome on the radio, opens with the same word. I was going to pick it.

Dec: Vey cut by candlelight. Roux had a lathe and a grudge. I'd be there till Easter.

Inès: Now you won't have to.

Dec: Remittere. Forgive.

La Taupe: Soufflot found the hill full of holes and nearly had a heart attack. An old gallery under the rue Clotilde runs up to the east end of the crypt.

La Taupe: To a shaft with a grille nobody's opened in two hundred years. It comes up in a little chapel off the crypt.

Dec: The north-east chapel. That's where they're putting my room.

That afternoon, four metres up a brick shaft, Inès clings to the rungs and doesn't look down. Through the rusted bars: the underside of pale new planks, stamped in blue by a timber yard in Montreuil.

Dec: That's my floor. They've built my room right on top of their own back door.

Dec: I'll open it tomorrow, from the top. Nobody'll need it. But I like to know there's a way out.

Mademoiselle Ferrand answered Inès in twelve minutes: of course the restorer may stay with her painting. Monsieur de Vaulmont would be delighted.

Dec: We're both inside, with a word for a lock in the roof and a back door in the cellar. And then what?

Inès: You look at the door. I look at the painting. We see what's wrong.

Dec: That's a terrible plan.

Inès: Yes.

Dec: Grand. I'm in.

Walk into the Panthéon on the first of April - turn to section 9.

12



Two hundred clocks on the walls, and every one of them stopped. Roux stands at the top of a stepladder with a winding key.

By the door stand Madame Ferré from the bakery and an old lady in a fur hat, who came in uninvited and won't leave.

Roux: I stopped them myself. Get that straight.

Roux: Yesterday at three I'm sitting here with the radio. The radio says the stations have all stopped at nine. Austerlitz, Montparnasse, Gare de Lyon. The traffic lights to the Seine.

The hospitals.

Roux: The man on the radio is frightened. So I look at my clocks.

Roux: Not one stopped. Not one of my clocks listens to Allouis, or to anybody. My clocks listen to me.

Roux: So this morning I stop them all. By hand. At nine. To see how it feels to do it to myself.

Inès: And how does it feel?

Roux: Stupid. Watch.

He touches the pendulum of the big walnut regulator on the top shelf, and it swings. Then the carriage clock, and the next, and the next, his small spotted hands working along the shelves, a touch or a turn of the key for each.

At the bottom of the ladder he opens the little door in the longcase, his father's clock, the chalk long wiped away. He gives the pendulum a push, the way you push a child on a swing.

The ticking comes up from every side like rain starting on a roof. One drop, then a dozen, then all of them, none together.

The cuckoo over the workshop door shoots out, says cuckoo once, as if clearing its throat, and goes back in.

Roux listens with his head on one side until he is satisfied.

Roux: There. That's the only miracle I've ever approved of.

The old lady in the fur hat bursts into tears.

Madame Ferré: There, madame. Have a croissant.

Dec: Could I have a croissant?

Madame Ferré: No.

White cloths, and the same eleven dishes since nineteen fifty-two. Pichon has been awake for thirty hours. He won't discuss the case before the second course, because at present he is not a just man.

The blanquette comes in a sauce so white and smooth Inès could lay gold leaf on it. Pichon puts down his fork.

Pichon: Fabien Ruel has confessed. To everything.

Pichon: The tea at the inn, Monsieur Hartley. Madame Aubry. The curate. Monsieur Roux's coffee. Monsieur Morel's tea. The clocks, every time.

Pichon: In great detail, with some pride, in the form of a sermon. My sergeant typed for four hours.

Pichon: He believes he will be forgiven. He was very struck by the word on the lock.

Pichon: Your young waiter is pressing no charges for the bite.

Dec: He bit Moussa?

Pichon: Moussa was sitting on him.

Pichon: Also, the Centre des monuments nationaux wants to keep your clockmaker's cell in the crypt until the end of the summer. An educational exhibit. They ask your fee.

Pichon: I told them it was very high.

Dec opens his mouth, and shuts it again.

Pichon: Kessler has said nothing at all. I'm told it's his custom. His hands match the marks on Maître Lassalle's arms. That will do.

Pichon: He asked one thing last night, through an interpreter. He speaks only Swiss German, and not much of that.

Pichon: He asked if someone could check the netting in the dome. For birds.

She keeps pushing it until she trusts her face again.

Pichon: Jean-Paul Morel woke at six this morning at the Hôtel-Dieu. He asked for his wife. Then he asked what day it was, and when they told him, he wept.

Pichon: The doctors think he'll be well. He wants to talk to me, at length. And to you, Madame Varga, when you can bear it.

Pichon: I told him that might be some time.

Inès: It might not.

She is surprised to hear herself say it.

Pichon: At seven this morning the minister rang the prefect to thank him for his long service and accept his wish to spend more time in Normandy.

Pichon: The prefect didn't know he had that wish until seven. He has it now.

Pichon: The wine. Four jugs. Datura, clove, and the ash of

burnt paper. They're still working out what paper.

Dec: And Vaulmont?

Pichon puts his fork down again. From his raincoat on the back of the chair he takes a small evidence bag and sets it on the cloth between the bread basket and the salt.

Pichon: Released at four this morning. Bail of two million euros. The magistrate is a sensible woman. She wished to keep him.

Pichon: Paid in full at three fifty-one, from a foundation in Liechtenstein. It didn't exist on Tuesday. It doesn't exist this morning.

Pichon: A car was waiting at the quai des Orfèvres. No plane. No train. He has simply gone.

Pichon: He left this. They took it from him at the Panthéon with his tie and his belt. At four, he didn't ask for it back.

Inès opens the back of the watch through the plastic with her thumbnail, the way she did on the Pont de Sully, a week and a lifetime ago. Where Lassalle's watch had nine little wheels, this one has a single engraved line.

Inès: The seventh of nine.

Dec sets his glass down on the cloth very carefully, as if it might go off. At the next table someone laughs. A waiter drops a spoon. In the kitchen, somebody is singing.

Dec: So there are eight more.

Pichon: There are eight more.

Pichon: The Swiss searched the forester's house last night. The black notebook and the board were in the stove, half burnt. Vey's ledger was not.

Pichon: Fabien says it went to the Seventh. So it went with him.

Pichon: One of the others is called the Keeper of the Last Hour. Though I'm told that's a story nuns tell each other in the evenings.

He slips the bag back into his raincoat.

Pichon: I'll keep this. As a reminder. I have a very bad memory.

Pichon: Now. The cheese, the tarte Tatin, and nineteen hours of sleep. And neither of you is going to be in the next case of anything. You hear me?

Dec: We hear you.

Pichon, who doesn't believe a word of it, calls for the cheese.

Clothilde: They've taken the wall down! The commune, this morning. The fire brigade did it. You can see the whole dial from the village. All nine hours.

Clothilde: Madame Jobin's nephew went up the ladder with a pot of grease and a library book. He's put the old twelve-hour wheel back. The one my sisters took out in sixteen ten.

Clothilde: It struck four just now. Four times. Not thirteen. The whole valley came out to listen. I cried.

Clothilde: I've been on the plum brandy since lunch. Is he there? Your not-husband?

Inès: He's carrying a toolbox.

Clothilde: Good. Give him a kiss from me. On the forehead. Don't let him make it into anything.

She rings off.

Dec: What did she want?

Inès: Nothing. Coffee.

Low gold light comes through the skylight and lies across the benches and the jars of pigment like varnish.

It will be evidence for months, maybe years. But the magistrate agreed that a half-cleaned seventeenth-century canvas can't wait for the courts. Over the cheese, Pichon told Inès: she goes on, under seal. Something in her chest came loose that she hadn't known was tight.

She won't paint the word back in. A restorer doesn't. She'll stabilise the scrape, clean round it, and leave the gap honest. Anyone who looks properly will see where someone took a knife to the thing they were most afraid of.

Behind her, Dec kneels at the atelier door with the old lock half out, the one that has stuck every winter for four years. He has been humming for twenty minutes. He is very happy. She can tell from the humming.

Dec: This is a terrible lock. Who put this in? It's a crime against doors. I'm going to put in a five-lever mortice with a...

Inès: Dec.

Dec: Hm?

Inès: We're not partners.

The screwdriver stops.

Dec: No.

Inès: But this building has fourteen doors. Every lock is terrible. And I'm going to need somebody who can get into places.

She turns round. He is sitting back on his heels, mouth a little open, the gold light in his untidy hair.

Inès: It's a job. That's all. It pays very badly.

Dec: How badly?

Inès: Very.

Dec: Will there be tea?

Inès: There might be tea.

Then the grin comes, the whole enormous Galway grin, the one that looked at her through the back window of a police car eleven days ago.

Dec: Ah, go on, then. Purely professionally.

Inès: Purely professionally.

Four floors down, the street-door bell rings.

A courier in a motorcycle helmet wouldn't come up, wouldn't

say who sent it, and was gone before Dec reached the last flight.

They look at it without touching it. Then Inès puts on her white cotton gloves, because that's what she does, and slits one edge with her scalpel.

Inès: Eight.

Across the roofs of the Marais a church bell begins to strike six. She finds herself counting. Beside her, under his breath, in English, Dec is counting too. They both stop at six, and look at each other, and go on looking.

Dec: Well. That's not a partnership. That's an invitation.

Inès lays the clock face back in its tissue and closes the box. She takes off her gloves and pushes her glasses up with one knuckle.

Inès: Get your coat.

The miracle fails, Vaulmont walks, and HUIT calls them out

The End.

Turn to section 1 to start again.

13



Dark blue window, the church bell across the road striking six, very slow. A laptop screen turned down as dim as it goes.

She counts the strokes and is relieved when they stop at six. Then she opens photograph twenty-three, raking light from the left, and enlarges the gap in the Latin line until it fills the screen.

Inès: Whoever scraped the word went through the paint. Not through the ground underneath.

Inès: And a painter who letters a motto draws it first. He

marks the spacing with little ticks, so the word will fit.

She counts them three times. Nine. She writes it in her notebook.

Inès: Nine letters. A word for what happens to a loan, at the ninth hour.

Through the connecting door Dec falls over something, swears, and starts singing in the shower with astonishing confidence and very little tune.

Inès: His landlord was right about that.

A hand-painted sign on the door: Ouvert quand c'est ouvert. Inside it ticks, louder and less politely than Roux's shop. Painted farmhouse clocks, watchmakers' benches left as if for lunch a century ago, a whole wall of cuckoo clocks that Dec eyes with deep personal suspicion.

Clothilde: The couple at Madame Jobin's. The honeymoon that isn't. Coffee?

Inès: We're not...

Clothilde: Of course not. Nobody is, at first. Sit, sit. You're here about the priory.

Inès: How do you know?

Clothilde: Nobody comes to Les Bréviaires in March except for the priory. And the young man who has rented the forester's house asked me yesterday whether two people from Paris had been asking.

Clothilde: Monsieur Ruel. Fabien. He signed the commune register like a schoolboy. I don't like him. He reads timetables for pleasure.

Inès puts the silver watch on the table between the cups. The amusement goes out of the old nun's face like light out of a valley under a cloud.

Clothilde: Ah. Yes. Then you'd better have the whole of it.

Clothilde: Combe-Noire was a little priory. Twelve monks and some sheep. In thirteen forty-nine the plague came up from Basel and half the plateau died.

Clothilde: One of the monks was a clockmaker, a new and strange thing to be. Anselm Vey.

Dec: The lock.

Clothilde: The lock, the clock, everything. He preached that God was a lender. That He had lent us every hour as a loan, and now the loan was being called in.

Clothilde: So Vey built the Debt Clock to keep the account. Nine hours on its dial, because the ninth was the hour of reckoning. He rang the valley's hours. When to work, to pray, to pay.

Clothilde: Whoever holds the clock holds the time of everyone who can hear it.

Inès thinks of Roux: every radio clock in France listens to the one voice. She can feel Dec not looking at her.

Inès: And those who didn't pay?

Clothilde: They were given the Grey Communion. Datura seed steeped in wine, cloves to hide the taste, and ash from the burnt accounts of the dead. That is what turns the tongue grey.

Clothilde: A man drank it and lost a day. He woke with the clock stopped at the ninth hour, and the monks said the hour had been taken as payment. He had the day missing. He had the taste in his mouth. So he paid.

The cuckoo clocks strike ten, one after another. Nobody speaks until they finish.

Clothilde: In sixteen ten my order, the Visitation sisters, came up with the bishop's soldiers. The brothers were turned out, the clock was walled up and the stair broken.

Clothilde: The Brotherhood went down to the cities and became bankers. Much the same thing, with better shoes. I'm the last sister in the Jura. My turn to forget.

Inès: You haven't, though.

Clothilde: No. I'm very bad at it.

Clothilde: The sisters told a story that Vey repented at the end. That he wrote one last line in his great ledger, a confession, and it was scraped out.

Clothilde: My sisters burnt half the ledger when they walled up the clock. The other half they never found.

Inès: Vey kept it in his book. That's what Roux was told.

She shows the nun the notebook page and tells her about the

painting: the clock with IX at the top, mutuo datum, hora nona, the scraped word.

Clothilde: Hora nona. In a monastery that is not nine o'clock. The monks counted from dawn. None, the ninth hour, is three in the afternoon. The hour of the reckoning.

Inès's hand goes to the cream card in her pocket. She knows it by heart. Panthéon. Le premier avril. Quinze heures précises.

Inès: Fifteen hundred. The ninth hour.

Clothilde: They've bought the priory, you know. Last autumn. A foundation from Paris with a name like a wine. Valmont. Vaumont.

Inès: Vaulmont.

Clothilde: They changed every lock they could. Not this one. It's in the listed wall and the commune wouldn't let them.

She puts a black iron key as long as her hand on the table.

Clothilde: The abbess's key, to the tower door. It's been in my drawer forty years and I'm tired of it.

Dec: It's his. Vey's. The little brother of the one Roux made. Look how thin he cut those wheels. With a file, by candlelight, in a plague.

Inès: If it's open, the letters are still set. Can you read the word?

Dec: Somebody's spun them. All nine. After. It doesn't tell you

anything except he was very good.

Clothilde: The sisters found it in his cell, open, as if he had opened it himself before he died. My predecessor called it the only honest thing in the priory. A lock that had given up.

Through the tall window, the black tower of Combe-Noire stands against a pewter sky. A very long way up.

A shelf of open hillside above the spruce. A broken grey wall iced with snow, and in its corner a square black tower. High on its face, a great iron dial three metres across, with a single iron hand.

Fabien was seen taking the little red train to Delémont at noon. Dec has fallen over four times on the way up. Inès waited each time without turning round, and he is grateful.

Inès: Count them. There are only nine.

The old oak door has a lock plate the size of a dinner plate. Dec rocks the abbess's key gently, feeling the levers like a tooth with his tongue. Something in the door groans like an old man getting out of a chair, and turns.

Hollow all the way up like a chimney. The old stair broken into stubs. A brand-new steel ladder zigzags up the walls, bolts still bright.

Dec: They've spent a lot of money on a heritage nobody's allowed to visit.

Near the top, behind him on the rungs, Inès says something quiet in Hungarian that is either a prayer or the opposite.

Through a trap in a wooden floor, the clock fills the room: a cage of black iron the size of a garden shed, huge hand-cut wheels, a stone weight on a chain hanging down into the dark.

Dec: It's the one in the drawings. The actual one. Six hundred and seventy-five years.

Inès: Can you open it without the word?

Dec: Machine-cut gates, you need the word or a drill. But hand-cut, by candlelight, by a man in a hurry because the world was ending? There's play. A hair.

Dec: Pull on the shackle, turn a wheel slow, and you feel the gate go past the bar. Give me a minute. Don't talk to me.

Inès: I wasn't going to.

Dec: I know. I'm talking to me.

Eyes shut, he turns the first wheel. Nothing. Nothing. A tiny give.

Dec: One.

Snow blows in through the slits. He warms his fingers in his armpits and starts again. Four. Five. Six. The seventh is stuck with six centuries of grime. The ninth takes longest of all.

A sound so small he feels it more than hears it. The bar drops.

Inès: What does it say? What word did you open it with?

Dec: Nothing. Q, F, Z, A... I went by the gates, not the letters. Somebody's had the wheels off and put them back in a different order. Recently.

Inside, a huge red leather book, its back half burnt to a black crust.

Inès: Vey's ledger. Horae solutae. The hours paid. And the last page before the burn, in a big shaking hand...

Dec: Remit. That's English.

Inès: It's Latin first. Remittere. To send back. To forgive a debt. It's cut off. It could fit the gap.

The other two things are new. A fat black notebook in neat blue biro, and a circuit board in a silver bag.

Dec: Allouis. The voice the clocks listen to. Local replacement.

Inès turns the pages fast, the way she never turns pages.

Dec: That's Pichon's text. That was them. A test.

One line alone on the next page, written carefully, the thing he was working towards.

Inès: Five kilometres. The whole centre of Paris. Every station, every traffic light, every hospital clock. At three o'clock, in an eclipse, with the city in the street looking up.

Dec: And a man in a nice suit on the telly saying look, the clocks have stopped, God's calling in the debt. It's not a miracle. It's a radio.

Inès: Photograph it all. Mine's on four per cent.

He photographs every page as fast as he has ever done anything. He is checking the last when, far below, the oak door groans open.

Feet on the steel ladder. One light and quick. One so heavy the whole ladder hums.

Inès: Phones inside your clothes. Not your pockets.

He shoves both down his jumper against his skin. They are so cold he gasps.

Fabien: Every hour is lent. Every hour lent is owed. You are in a private building, Madame Varga. Monsieur Hartley.

Dec: We had a key.

Fabien: Of course you did.

The bald man holds out his hand to Inès, palm up. Not threatening. Waiting, the way you wait for a child to give back what it should not have picked up.

She puts the notebook in it.

Fabien: And the board, please. And the book.

The bald man carries the ledger down flat on both palms, as if it were a sleeping animal. Fabien shuts the iron box and spins the nine wheels with one sweep, like shuffling cards.

From the trap, only his head and shoulders showing, he looks back.

Fabien: Minus twenty tonight on the plateau, they say. The Clockless One lends us every hour. Tonight, perhaps, you'll learn the price of one.

The trap bangs down. Underneath it, the bright modern snap of a steel padlock. Far below, the oak door, and the abbess's

key turning in it from outside.

Dec: Well. That's my key gone.

The wind rises to a howl. Inès moves a step closer to him, and then another.

Hold on through the night together - turn to section 16.

14



La Taupe kills her lamp. Inès's thumb stays on her switch, and she doesn't press it. Dec plants himself in the doorway and holds his beam high down the gallery.

La Taupe: Putain. T'es un con. Un beau con.

The chanting stops. The candles stop. Then they come on again, faster.

Dec: Bonsoir, les gars. Je suis… un touriste.

Inès counts. It's all she has. Eighteen. Tonight they don't take

the niches. They make a ring, and the three of them are inside it.

The biggest hood steps out. A shovel hand lifts Dec's satchel and pulls out the canvas roll.

Dec: Ah, non. Pas les couverts.

The ninth pair reaches the altar. One of them turns.

VOICE: Monsieur Hartley.

Quiet. Cultured. Warm oil, poured slowly.

VOICE: You were engaged to build my cell. Not to visit my chapel.

Dec: You know my name.

VOICE: We know everyone's name. It is the nature of a ledger.

Dec swings his lamp full on the hood, and Inès's beam joins it. The man doesn't flinch. He lowers the hood himself, as if they had asked politely.

He draws a watch from the waistcoat and opens it toward them.

Dec: Silver hair. A voice like warm oil. A watch with no hands.

Dec: You're Roux's gentleman.

VOICE: Look as long as you like, Monsieur Hartley. You won't keep it.

The bald man lifts the lamp off Dec's head, gently, like taking scissors from a child. Then Inès's. He turns them both to the

floor.

Dec backs until his heels hit stone. He doesn't stop talking.

Dec: Total malentendu. Mauvais virage rue Saint-Jacques. Signalisation pourrie, ici.

Behind his back, low at the rusted grille, Inès hears the tiniest scratch of steel. One pick, kept up his sleeve.

Dec: Et puisque vous êtes là. La cellule. La porte s'ouvre dedans ou dehors? Dedans pour le drame. Dehors pour les pompiers.

VOICE: Dehors, je pense.

Scratch. Two hoods near the altar turn toward the sound.

Inès steps into the candlelight before her knees can vote.

Inès: Mutuo datum.

Every hood turns.

Inès: It's on my painting, under the varnish. Mutuo datum. Donné en prêt. Given as a loan.

Inès: Un prêt demande un prêteur. A lender, a borrower, a contract. Who signed for the city? Who signed for Roux?

VOICE: Madame Varga. Jean-Paul told me you were minutieuse. Thorough.

He is enjoying this. She can hear it: a man who has waited years for someone worth explaining to.

VOICE: God signed. He lent the hours. Brother Vey only kept

the accounts.

Inès: Datum. Given. Done. Then a hole where somebody took a knife. You've built a church on half a sentence.

VOICE: Then you know how the sentence ends.

Behind her, a small dry click. The grille screams open, and the sound circles the chapel three times.

Dec: Taupe! Go!

La Taupe dives into the black hole headfirst, like a letter into a postbox. Water splashes. Then nothing.

The bald man's hand closes on Dec's shoulder. It isn't rough. It doesn't need to be.

A hood moves toward the drain.

VOICE: Laissez-la. Qui croirait une cataphile? Elles voient des fantômes ici tous les week-ends.

Inès: Leave her. Who would believe a cataphile? They see ghosts down here every weekend.

VOICE: Mutuo datum.

HOODS: Reddetur.

Inès: It shall be repaid.

The silver-haired man opens the ledger to the debtors' page and uncaps a fountain pen. The nib whispers.

A pewter cup passes hand to hand round the ring. Two hoods hold Inès's arms. She clamps her mouth shut. A gloved thumb

presses her jaw, almost kindly, until it opens.

Sweet and dusty. Then flat and mineral at the back of the tongue, like cold wet stone.

Inès: Cloves. Cloves and slate. Roux said cloves.

Across the ring, Dec swallows, coughs, and finds her eyes.

Dec: Inès. His face. Hold on to his face.

She looks. Silver hair. Grey eyes. The watch with no hands. She says it over to herself like a phone number.

VOICE: Don't be afraid. You owe us only a day.

The candles go very far away.

Low sun on the Seine, green-grey water, bare trees at the tip of the Île Saint-Louis. A jogger passes and doesn't look twice.

Her mouth tastes of slate. She doesn't know why.

Inès: Dec. Dec. Why are we on a bridge?

Dec: What... I don't know. What time is it? We're meeting La Taupe tonight. It's Wednesday.

Inès: It's Wednesday.

She checks her watch.

Dec licks dry lips. She grabs his chin.

He looks at her mouth and goes white.

He rips open the satchel. No pick roll. No cardboard tube of Roux's drawings. No silver watch.

Dec: Gone. The watch. The drawings. Everything.

Inès: Who took them?

He opens his mouth. Nothing comes.

Dec: There was a face. I looked right at it. Silver... something.

Dec: I had it, Inès. I had it, and it's gone.

She reaches for it too. Candles, a ring of hoods, a face. Where the face should be there is a smooth blank band, like the sundial before the raking light.

Her phone wakes in her pocket.

Inès: Friday.

Dec: It can't be Friday. It was Wednesday. Where's Thursday?

Inès: She waited for us at the way out. She rang all day Thursday. And we weren't anywhere.

His phone buzzes. He reads it and holds it out.

Dec: Vaulmont. The fella paying for my cell.

The skin on Inès's arms rises under her coat. She can't say why.

Inès: Say the name again.

Dec: Vaulmont.

Neither of them knows why it makes them want to run.

Across the river, a church bell starts to strike. Inès counts every stroke without meaning to.

It stops at nine.

Caught and Stopped, the Brotherhood keeps a day of them

The End.

Turn to section 1 to start again.

15



A top-floor workshop under a grey skylight. The radiator knocks like a polite ghost. On the big easel, a dark old painting, a third of its sky cleaned to a cold clear blue.

An Allegory of the Sundial, French, about 1650. A woman in a garden rests one hand on a stone sundial and points at the sky with the other.

Inès: You had better not have been retouched in the eighteen hundreds. I don't have time for it.

The odd thing is the sundial. Its shadow falls on a smooth

blank band where the hours should run.

Morel: How far have you got?

Inès: A third of the sky.

Morel: En somme, Lassalle telephoned again. The client asks if we can finish by the end of the month.

Inès: We said the fifteenth of April.

Morel: Voilà, we said. But the client has an event on the first.

Inès: I am not taking a scalpel to a seventeenth-century sky because somebody is having a party. Who is the client?

Morel: Lassalle doesn't say. A private collection.

His eyes go straight to the sundial, and stay there.

Morel: And there's nothing unusual? Underneath? Old repairs, overpaint?

Inès: Why would there be?

Morel: No reason. I'll be in the office. If there's anything.

He shuts himself in his glass office and sits with his hands flat on the desk.

Inès: People don't ask that idly. They ask it about paintings they already know the answer to.

Under ultraviolet the old varnish shines a milky green. Except in one place.

On the face of the sundial the glow breaks into a faint dark ring, with twelve small marks round its rim.

She swaps the lamp for a raking light, almost flat to the canvas, so every ridge in the paint throws a shadow.

Inès: Paint remembers.

Below the dial runs a line of Roman capitals, also painted out. One word in the middle has been scraped away with a blade, down to the ground.

Inès: Mutuo datum. Given as a loan. And hora nona, the ninth hour.

She takes forty-one photographs and logs every one. A photograph without a note is a rumour.

Through the glass, Morel has not come out to ask why the blind is down. He is not looking at her, very hard.

At nine thirty-five the radio over the sink says rue des Gravilliers.

RADIO: An elderly clockmaker found confused in his shop… he had, quote, lost a day… all the clocks had been stopped…

Inès: Roux.

She looks at the painted clock with nine at the top. Then she pulls off her gloves, grabs her mustard scarf and takes the stairs at a speed her mother would not approve of.

Morel: Inès? Where are you…?

Inès: Coffee.

A police car half on the pavement. A small crowd with shopping trolleys, and a man with an elderly dachshund. The

dachshund looks at Inès. She goes round the other side of the trolleys.

Two officers steer a tall man out of the shop. He ducks a beat late and hits his head on the bell.

Dec: No, I understand, I'd arrest me too, on paper I look desperate...

He sees Inès and gives her an enormous hopeful smile.

Dec: Madame! Could you telephone to my client? J'ai un rendez-vous à onze heures! Je suis une serrure!

Inès: Je ne peux pas. Je vais être en retard.

Inès: And you are not a lock. You are a serrurier. A serrure is the thing you open.

Dec: Right. Thanks. That's actually very helpful. I'll know for next time.

Pichon: Walk, Monsieur Hartley.

As they fold him into the car, something falls from his jacket and rings across the cobbles to the toe of her grey boot.

Through the rear window the Irishman looks back at her, apologising or asking for help.

Inès pockets the gear and goes to find out where the police judiciaire has its lunch.

A bare table, a camera, and a door with a card reader and no keyhole, which Dec takes personally.

Pichon: You don't mind. If I don't eat at twelve I become

unjust. My wife says so.

Pichon: Your landlord says you are polite and sing in the shower. Your bank says less.

Pichon: And your back door was faked by someone who wishes the police to find a burglar. And go home.

He puts down his spoon and slides three photographs across the table.

Pichon: October, a retired judge. January, a bookseller. February, a curate at Saint-Médard. Every clock at nine. All said everything tasted of cloves.

Pichon: None of this was in the papers. Then a man on his knees in the fourth case tells me about the chalk and the cloves before I ask.

Dec: I just looked at what was there.

Pichon: Yes. That is the trouble. Most people don't.

An officer looks in. A woman downstairs has something of the prisoner's. She says the lobby coffee machine is a crime and should be arrested.

Inès: Commissaire. Inès Varga, restorer, Atelier Morel. This fell out of his pocket.

She sets the brass gear on the table.

Dec: Oh, thanks. That's the pattern piece. It came with the parts list from my client.

Pichon: Who?

Inès: Who?

They say it together, and look at each other with mutual irritation.

Dec: The Fondation Vaulmont. Please match all wheels to this pattern. I thought it was their logo...

He turns it to the light, sees the IX for the first time, and puts it down.

Inès: I saw this mark this morning. Under the varnish of a painting from about sixteen fifty.

Inès: A clock with nine at the top, painted out. A Latin line about a loan and the ninth hour, with one word scraped away. I have photographs.

Pichon takes off his reading glasses and presses the bridge of his nose.

Pichon: Of course you do.

Pichon: Monsieur Hartley, I have nothing against you but bad luck and a bag of little knives. Madame Varga, I keep the gear. Send me your photographs.

Pichon: Then go home, both of you. If I find you in the fifth case, I will be very sad, I will eat a large lunch, and then I will put you in a cell.

Dec: There's a fifth?

Pichon: There is always a fifth.

He goes back inside.

Dec: Thanks. For coming.

Inès: I didn't come for you. I came for the mark.

Dec: We're not, you know. Partners or anything.

Inès: No. We are not partners.

Dec: Grand. Glad we sorted that.

They stand in the drizzle not being partners. A bus goes by.

His phone rings. A Paris number.

Ferrand: Monsieur Hartley? Mademoiselle Ferrand, Fondation Vaulmont. We heard about this morning's unpleasantness.

Ferrand: The clockmaker's cell must be installed by the thirty-first. The vigil is on the first of April, the day of the eclipse. Nothing about it can move.

Ferrand: Monsieur de Vaulmont sends his regards.

The line goes dead.

Dec: They knew I'd been arrested. Before I'd told a soul.

Inès: Who sent you the parts list?

Dec digs a crumpled envelope out of his satchel. The sender's stamp is a notary's.

Inès: Lassalle. That's the broker for my painting.

Drizzle beads on her glasses.

Inès: We are still not partners.

Dec: Course not.

Meet Inès at Lassalle's office in the morning - turn to section 2
.

16



Black iron cage, black beams. Snow sifts through the slits and settles without melting.

Dec spent half an hour flat on the boards with his thinnest pick, then two picks tied with a bootlace. The padlock sits on the far side of the trap.

Dec: Give me a keyhole and I'll open anything. They didn't give me a keyhole. They gave me a floor.

He kills his phone torch to save the battery. Hers died at five past four.

Inès mutters something long and vicious in Hungarian.

Dec: Say the one with the horse again.

Inès: It isn't about a horse. It's about your mother and a horse. I'm sorry. I don't know your mother.

Dec: She'd love you. She'd be terrified of you.

Minus twenty, Fabien said. Her fingers won't bend. She feels warm and heavy and sleepy, and some old part of her knows that is the bad sign.

Inès: Talk to me. You always talk. Don't let me sleep.

Dec: Right. Right. I've a story about a door in Salthill.

Mrs Kilbride, a stuck mortice, a cat called Pádraig and a sandwich. He tells it in the dark, with both arms.

Dec: ...and Pádraig had the sandwich the whole time. Your turn. Tell me something true.

She is too cold to decide not to.

Inès: My father lost days. Zoltán. He drove a bus in Lyon for thirty years and knew every street.

Inès: He taught me to swear in Hungarian. And to look at things. Ne csak nézd, lásd. Don't just look. See.

Inès: At the end he'd wake up in nineteen ninety and dress for work. Every morning I told him, and every morning he was frightened.

Inès: These people do it on purpose. Like taking a coin out of a fountain. And they call it a religion.

Inès: That's why I came.

Dec blows into his hands, twice.

Dec: I'm sorry. Mine dropped dead in the van, outside a chipper on Shop Street. I was in Dublin, wearing a lanyard, because the shop was a bit small for me.

Dec: I wasn't there. So I ran his shop into the ground, and then I started locking people in rooms. Because I couldn't get out of one.

Inès: You're not that. I watched you open that lock without the word. You're the most stubborn person I've ever met, and I've met my mother.

He leans against her shoulder, and the shivering stops.

Dec: We'll not mention any of this. After.

Inès: Never.

Dec: Grand.

Inès: Dec. The torch. Point it up.

Through a square hole in the ceiling the beam finds the bell, huge and green-black, the iron hammer poised beside it. Letters run round its lip.

Inès laughs, short and cracked.

Inès: The hour is struck by whoever winds. Trahere, to draw up the weight. Whoever holds the clock holds the time.

Inès: Dec. Can you make this go?

The great stone weight hangs on its chain into the dark. Beside the frame, a square iron shaft, and on the floor a crank some clock-keeper left four hundred years ago.

Dec: Ah, now. Ah, now.

Every turn takes everything they have. After fifty she isn't cold. After a hundred she's sweating. In the cage a ratchet goes clack, clack, like a huge slow heart.

Dec: This is the striking weight. When it's up, I pull this lever and she strikes. Hold the lever and she keeps striking.

Inès: Then don't let go.

He reaches into the cage up to the shoulder. She nods. He pulls.

BONG.

The note hits them in the teeth and the ribs, and snow drops off the beams in a cloud. Inès claps her hands over her ears and laughs.

Seven. Eight. Nine. Out through the slits, down the valley, over the sleeping farms.

Ten. Eleven. Twelve.

Thirteen.

Dec lets go. The silence rings.

Her hand touches paper, wedged under the bottom bar of the frame. The winding has shaken it out an inch. It is a leaf of parchment with a charred edge, a page the sisters never

managed to burn.

Inès: I. Custos Horae Ultimae. The Keeper of the Last Hour.

Inès: The Collector.

Dec: The Seventh will collect.

Inès: They aren't people. They're offices, like a government. Somebody holds each one. Today.

Far down the valley a high, angry engine is coming. And sirens.

Bolt-cutters bite through the padlock. Up comes the volunteer fire brigade of Les Bréviaires in yellow helmets, all talking at once. The bell hasn't rung since sixteen ten.

Clothilde: Well. You've woken the dead. I suppose that's something.

Clothilde: Drink. Don't argue.

Coffee and plum brandy, half and half. It goes down like a lit match.

Dec's phone, warm from his skin, has six per cent. He scrolls back to the very first photograph, enlarges it and holds it out to her.

Inès knows the hand. Four years of yellow notes on her bench. Inès, client called again, voilà, could you possibly...

Inès: Our restorer is close to the word.

Inès: Not me. Him.

She watches the snow all the way down.

A white quilt, red geraniums on the sill, a travel clock by the bed and a cuckoo clock by the door. Roux's drawings are spread over the bed.

Inès is up at the museum with the brown page and a Latin dictionary the size of a breeze block. At breakfast they talked about the weather for twenty minutes, very carefully.

A knock. The corridor is empty. On the floor sits a tray: a white teapot, a cup, two biscuits and a card.

Dec: Ah, Madame Jobin. You're a dote.

The tea is hot and spiced. He drinks half the cup in one go.

Then he stops with the cup halfway to the saucer.

Something faint lies under the spice, sweet and dusty. Behind it sits something flat and mineral, like cold wet stone, at the back of his tongue. His tongue feels a size too big.

Dec: Madame Jobin never leaves a tray. She stays and asks about the honeymoon. Nobody stayed.

Dec: Ah, stop. It's the house blend. The cold's got into your head.

The pot is still nearly full, and he is still cold to the bone.

Cloves and slate, like Roux: spit it out and play dead - turn to section 5.

It's only the house's spiced tea: finish the cup - turn to section 8.